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tection from injury. The patient should be warned not to scratch the arm nor to prick the vesicles. He should also be cautioned not to apply vasoline or any other greasy substance to relieve the itching, as this softens the epidermis and may cause the vesicles to break down and suppurate. Ignorance and carelessness on the part of some patients is unavoidable, but personal attention to details is the part of the physician will do much to obviate this source of danger. The responsibility resting upon the physician in this matter is not a light one. If mishaps occur he is always blamed, whether justly or not. The sources of danger, as already pointed out, are not entirely under his control, but it is his duty, as well as his interest, to observe every precaution which will minimize the danger of vaccination, and yet afford his patients that immunity from smallpox which is one of the greatest blessings conferred on mankind by the art of medicine.

DISCUSSION.

DR. J. H. MCCOLLOM of Boston: I heartily coincide with Dr. Darling's ideas, and it seems to me that he has brought out some very interesting points. Having had a large experience, both before and after the epidemic of last fall and winter, I must confess that I think the majority of sore arms are due not so much to the carelessness of the individual, as to the physician in not giving sufficient directions.

VACCINATIONS: ACCIDENTS AND UNTOWARD EFFECTS.¹

BY JOHN H. MCCOLLOM, M.D., BOSTON.

In this paper no attempt will be made to prove the protective power of vaccination, a self-evident proposition, neither will anything be said regarding the technique of vaccination, these subjects having been ably treated in other papers presented to the society today. It must be taken for granted that vaccination is an operation, and that any operation, no matter how slight, may be followed by injurious effects, if there is carelessness in its performance or in the subsequent care of the wound. When we take into account the immense number of individuals vaccinated each year and the remarkable rarity of any serious results, the wonder is, if vaccination is such an injurious procedure as is claimed by its opponents, that there are not more disastrous effects. Many of the alleged injurious effects after careful investigation have been proved to have no connection with vaccination either directly or indirectly, but have been shown to be due to carelessness on the part of the individual.

It has been alleged that syphilis is frequently caused by vaccination. While this may have been possible in certain rare instances when humanized lymph was used, it is impossible when bovine lymph is employed. It has happened to the writer in several instances to investigate alleged occurrences of communication of syphilis, but in each case careful investigation revealed

the fact that the individuals were suffering from the primary lesion of syphilis at the time they were vaccinated, and that vaccination was used as a cloak to cover this condition. As an illustration of the manner in which vaccination is unjustly accused of conveying syphilis, Dr. Cory, in his "Theory and Practice of Vaccination,"² describes very aptly the following case of a child whose father contracted syphilis shortly after his marriage. Dr. Cory says: "It was the second child of the marriage; the first died within a very short period of birth. This child, being apparently healthy, was vaccinated at St. Thomas's Hospital in 1878. It was duly inspected, and was brought again with the eruption, which first appeared on the tenth day after vaccination. This is a very good example of the cases of alleged syphilis after vaccination. It is so tempting for parents to lay the results of their own iniquities upon vaccination, especially when they are encouraged so to do by shameless agitators. To enable us to view the truth of these allegations against vaccination, we will suppose a man to have had syphilis and to play a game of football; he receives a kick on the shin, and in due course a syphilitic node may develop from the bruise. The man would be as entitled to say he acquired his syphilis from playing football as a parent of a child who has had syphilis would be to say that the child acquired its syphilis from vaccination."

Erysipelas may follow vaccination, but there is no proof that the specific organism of this disease is in the vaccine lymph. Erysipelas also frequently follows the scratch of a pin or any slight abrasion, but this is no argument against vaccination but it is an argument for the careful protection of the vaccine vesicle. Urticaria may follow vaccination just the same as that the ingestion of fish and other food may also cause this troublesome eruption. Impetigo contagiosa sometimes appears after vaccination, but as impetigo is an extremely common disease, there is no proof that the vaccination is the cause of this manifestation, as the disease is fully as frequent among children who have not been recently vaccinated as among those who have been recently vaccinated.

Abscesses in the axilla may follow a vaccination, but this condition is extremely rare, and in my experience it has always been due to some carelessness on the part of the individual.

The site of the vaccination may slough, but I have never seen any serious result other than a somewhat tedious healing follow this condition. When this sloughing takes place it is always due either to a diminished vitality of the individual or carelessness in using the arm.

It is doubtful if cutaneous tuberculosis is ever communicable by vaccination, but the abraded surface if brought in contact with the sputum of a tuberculous patient may be infected. This is only another argument in favor of carefully protecting the site of the vaccination. As illustrating how the abraded surface may become

² Lectures on the Theory and Practice of Vaccination. By Robert Cory, M.A., M.D., Cantab., F.R.C.P., London, p. 65.

¹ Read before The Massachusetts Medical Society, June 10, 1902.

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